

A Starbucks APP Marketing Strategy for international Students in North America

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01

Core Story & Creative Motivation



A Warm Emotional Companion

The Starbucks APP is not merely an efficient digital ordering tool, but a warm emotional companion for Chinese international students in North America. It transcends transactional utility, weaving convenience, comfort, and a subtle sense of home into the fabric of their busy, unfamiliar lives abroad.



Eliminates Boredom

Customized coffee and one-click online ordering eliminate the tediousness of offline waiting. It turns wasted queuing time into precious moments for focused study or a much-needed pause in a busy student schedule.



Heals Loneliness

In the quiet moments of overseas study, a familiar cup of coffee becomes a gentle remedy for solitude. The familiar taste and ritual offer a small but deeply comforting sense of belonging in a foreign and often overwhelming environment.



Warm Bond

It acts as a heartfelt bridge across distances. Sending a Starbucks gift card or a drink to a fellow student becomes a simple yet powerful way to share warmth, care, and a small piece of home when words are hard to find.

INSIGHT FROM SEATTLE: A LIFESTYLE GAP

Based on on-the-ground experience in Seattle, we identified a critical opportunity: while North American students rely heavily on Starbucks as a daily lifestyle staple (unlike Australia's localized café culture), many overlook the APP's transformative convenience. This disconnect is more than a usability issue—it's a chance to deliver not just coffee, but a more seamless, emotionally resonant experience that understands and supports the unique journey of studying abroad.

A Full-Level Communication System

SME Educational Video

2-min Practical Guide

Purpose: Drink customization teaching for new users, simplifying the ordering process.

Goal: Functional popularization to empower customers with personalized choices.

Promotional Flash Video

15-20 sec Viral Clip

Purpose: Trend grass-planting across social platforms to capture attention.

Goal: Create instant buzz and drive quick engagement for new product exposure.

Heartfelt Mini-Documentary

2-3 min Storytelling

Purpose: Recording real, warm stories of overseas students and their coffee moments.

Goal: Elicit deep emotional resonance and build a warm, human-centric brand image.

This multi-tiered content strategy seamlessly blends education, inspiration, and emotional storytelling. By addressing practical needs, igniting trend awareness, and fostering genuine connections, we create a holistic brand experience that resonates deeply with the target audience and reinforces our commitment to human connection.

02

Problem Value & Significance



For Target Users: Efficiency & Healing



Time Waste

Offline queuing consumes valuable hours for busy students. Tight schedules mean every minute lost in line is time taken away from critical study sessions or much-needed rest.



Loneliness

Living abroad often brings a quiet sense of isolation. In unfamiliar surroundings, individuals seek simple, low-cost methods to find comfort and a momentary escape from loneliness.

The Weight of Daily Struggles

For international students navigating a new culture, these small frustrations compound. Wasted time and emotional distance create a desire for solutions that are both practical and emotionally resonant.



Efficiency

The Starbucks APP eradicates the need for physical queues. Pre-order and pick-up functionality streamlines the process, giving students back control over their busy schedules.



Warmth

A familiar cup of coffee becomes a gentle ritual. This small, consistent pleasure acts as a bridge to home, infusing the mundane routines of overseas life with a sense of comfort.

The Perfect Antidote

By combining speed with a human touch, the Starbucks APP doesn't just solve a logistical problem—it nurtures well-being. It's a small but meaningful way to make a big difference in the daily lives of international students.

For Starbucks Brand: Growth & Image

High Potential, Low Penetration

Chinese students (18–28) represent a core high-value demographic, yet their digital APP adoption remains low, leaving significant growth untapped.

Solidified Offline Habits

Deep-rooted traditional consumption behaviors create strong inertia. Users prefer in-store experiences, resisting the shift to self-service digital solutions.

Targeted Education

Tailored campaigns break inertia, guiding young users to embrace the ease of digital ordering.

Operational Efficiency

Increases digital penetration while streamlining store workflows for faster, smoother service.

Brand Resonance

Crafts a warm, healing identity in the youth community, fostering deeper emotional loyalty.

Bridging Hearts and Technology: A New Chapter for Starbucks China

03

Target Audience Profile



Profile: 18–28yo Chinese Students in North America

Age & Status

Undergraduate and postgraduate students form the core of this young consumer group. They demonstrate a strong acceptance of new digital products and are deeply moved by emotional content. As digital natives, they are quick to adapt to technological trends and value authentic, meaningful connections in their consumption choices.

Gender

We see full gender coverage with no specific preference. Both male and female students share a rigid, daily demand for coffee—primarily as a functional aid for intense study sessions and a reliable stress reliever during exams and deadlines. Coffee has become an indispensable part of their academic and social lifestyle.

Location

Concentrated in major North American cities including Seattle, New York, and Toronto—areas characterized by dense university campuses and a high saturation of Starbucks stores. Their daily mobility revolves around academic institutions and urban hotspots, making these locations prime for targeted brand interactions.

Traits & Hobbies

Highly active on YouTube and Instagram, they consume short-form videos and overseas lifestyle content daily. They pursue efficient, high-quality living and resist cumbersome offline experiences. Craving emotional companionship and small life rituals, they prefer authentic, healing, and trendy content over rigid, overly commercial advertising.

04

Distribution Platforms & Reasons



Strategic Platform Selection



YouTube

SME Video + Mini Documentary

Why Choose This Platform?

A leading platform for in-depth long-form content and searchability. It boasts high user browsing willingness and strict content completion rates, making it ideal for delivering complex stories that require focus and immersion.

Strategic Role & Impact

Adapts perfectly to educational content and emotional mini-documentaries. This platform enables long-term user education, fosters deep emotional resonance, and facilitates the precipitation of core brand assets—building a lasting cognitive foundation for the audience.



Instagram

Promotional Video (Reels)

Why Choose This Platform?

A lightweight short-video platform dominated by Reels, focusing on fragmented browsing and instant interactive experiences. It perfectly caters to the fast-paced content consumption habits of modern users, especially younger demographics.

Strategic Role & Impact

Ideal for fast-paced, inspirational flash videos. Its trendy youth ecology drives rapid content fission, creating short-term traffic explosions. This platform excels at capturing fleeting attention and promoting immediate user conversion and action.

05

\$10,000 Full Marketing Budget Allocation



Budget Breakdown

SME Educational Video

\$1,800

Production (\$800) covers core filming & editing. YouTube Promotion (\$1,000) drives targeted reach to student audiences.

Promotional Inspirational Video

\$2,200

High-quality production (\$1,200) for visual polish. Instagram Promotion (\$1,000) leverages platform algorithms for engagement.

Mini Student Documentary

\$4,500

Largest allocation for in-depth storytelling (\$3,500). YouTube push (\$1,000) ensures this flagship content gains meaningful traction.



06

Project Reflection & Learning Outcomes



Future Creation Suggestions & Core Gains

Balance

Harmonize visual aesthetics with commercial value. Find the perfect middle ground where artistic expression elevates the brand story while still driving measurable market performance and engagement.

Customization

Embrace brand-specific content creation and audience-centric refinement. Tailor the narrative style and visual language to align with the unique identity of each brand and the preferences of its target users.

CTA Guidance

Integrate natural and intuitive Call-to-Action prompts. Design guidance that feels organic to the content flow, effectively steering user behavior to form a complete and effective marketing conversion loop.

Smart Distribution

Utilize platform attributes and algorithm insights. Execute differentiated distribution strategies across channels to ensure content reaches the right audience at the optimal time for maximum impact.

Quarterly Core Gains



Thank You

